forces per capita in Indian-administered Kashmir remained one of the highest in the world; and Lashkar's main base was closer to Indian-administered Kashmir than Afghanistan, making it imperative to fight there first.[74] Zaki-ur Rehman Lakhvi also made the point that Lashkar had built its reputation in Indian-administered Kashmir and remained close to the population there, meaning it could perform jihad better than in Afghanistan where it would be difficult to replicate its success.[75] Yet this did not stop him from steering a small, but steady, flow of fighters toward Afghanistan once the decision was made to open a second front there.[76]

Several factors likely influenced this decision. First, although Lashkar was not facing mass desertion, joining the insurgency in Afghanistan was a means to keep its cadres on side. The Kashmir jihad was flagging, in part because the state was restraining it, and even some Lashkar members who favored this cause over fighting against America and its allies began leaving for want of an open front. Others were drawn to the Afghan jihad because of the success other actors were having there. Just as Lashkar's reputation as the most aggressive and committed group fighting in Indian-administered Kashmir had swelled its ranks during that conflict's heyday, it now risked losing current and potential members for the same reason. Still others had become motivated more by waging jihad against the 'Crusaders' in Afghanistan than the Hindu occupiers in Indian-administered Kashmir.[77] The issue of preserving personnel was particularly important in terms of Lashkar's commanders, who were more difficult to replace than rank-and-file recruits. For example, a senior commander and one of the group's founders, known as Abdul Qadir, left to fight with the Taliban in 2005 in part because Lashkar was not prioritizing the Afghan jihad. (He was also a rival of Lakhvi's and hoped to replace him as Lashkar's top commander, suggesting personal dynamics also may have played a role.)[78] Second, in addition to the issue of manpower, some donors, particularly those in the Gulf, were more interested in funding jihad against America and its allies than they were in liberating Indian-administered Kashmir. Third, although it made no secret of prioritizing the Kashmir jihad, Lashkar was a pan-Islamist organization. Fighting on the Afghan front was not only ideologically appealing to some of its leaders; it was also difficult to justify abstaining from for others who might have preferred an ongoing exclusive focus on Kashmir. Finally, as already mentioned, growing Indian influence